

Brad Stevens' Defensive DNA and 6

Non-Negotiables To Success

By Daniel Benjamin

<https://www.breakthroughbasketball.com/coaching/stevens-coaching-style.html>

Brad Stevens is/has been considered to be one of the top young basketball coaches in the country for several years. The 39-year old has been a head coach for nine years with the last three being with the Boston Celtics.

Prior to coaching the Celtics, Stevens was head coach at Butler University where he broke the NCAA record for most wins in a coach's first three-years. He also became the youngest coach in Division I history to lead his team to the national championship game in back-to-back seasons when he guided the Bulldogs to consecutive runners-up finishes in 2010 and 2011.

Overall, Stevens compiled a 166-49 record in his six years at Butler. He led the Bulldogs to five NCAA appearances three Horizon League Tournament titles and two-30 win campaigns. Stevens was an assistant with Butler starting from 2001-2007.

Stevens is currently working on rebuilding the Celtics. After going 25-57 in his first NBA season, Stevens led the Celtics to a surprising 40-42 record and a playoff appearance last year.

3 Core Principles Of Brad Stevens' Coaching Philosophy / Style

Stevens' coaching philosophy centers around three core principles of commitment, selflessness and team unity.

Stevens is known for being calm and focused while on the sidelines – during games, you often see him quietly observing the action with his arms folded. Stevens rarely gets upset with an official's call or a mistake by a player, rather he prefers to focus on "the next play".

He is said to be very open and honest with his players while also holding them accountable for their actions. He talks to his players about embracing the process of growth -- in other words, the need to focus on how to get better every day in order to succeed later.

Stevens is a big believer in preparation and spends lots of time breaking down game tape as well as using statistical analytics.

Stevens' teams are generally focused around fundamentals and team-oriented basketball with a primary emphasis on defense.

Since Stevens has been in Boston, the Celtics' defense has improved.

Defensive Efficiency (Points Per 100 Possessions)

2013/14	-	105.2	(Ranked	20th)
2014/15	-	102.1	(Ranked	12th)
2015/16 - 100.6 (Ranked 4th through 68 games)				

Brad Stevens' Defensive DNA and 6 Non-Negotiables To Success

The rest of the article will take a look at Stevens' defensive philosophy.

Stevens broke his philosophy down to six parts or what he calls the DNA of defense. Stevens DNA consists of commitment, positioning, prioritizing, awareness execution/technique and completion.

1. Commitment

First and most importantly, players need to be committed to your system. Commitment starts with the right mindset, which should be believing in what you are doing, doing their job and being a great teammate. If you can get your players to believe, you can establish a Defensive DNA.

A good technique to keep your team interested/committed in your defensive system is to challenge them statistically.

For example, say who routinely hold your opponents to 45% shooting from the field set a goal to hold them to under 40% percent in your next game. Generally speaking your defensive field goal percentage drops 2% for every stop you get that would mean that you would need three more stops than normal.

2. Positioning

The first step in attaining the proper position is to get back on defense to stop any transition buckets. Four keys to halting any transition offense: stay in front of the ball, protect the basket, pick up the basketball and, last but not least, find the good shooters as so many teams are shooting three's in transition.

The next step is deciding how you want to defend the ball relative to where you are on the court. Do you want to play straight up, double-team, switch screens or blitz the screen, etc..

The last step in position is the close out.

The [proper technique in closing out](#) is to take three steps, then break down (chop your feet) with your hands up (remember hand down, man down) and close out to the shooter's dominant hand.

Remember that close outs are dependent on personnel, you want to close tight or fly by great shooters while you want to close out loosely on great drivers so you don't get beat off the dribble.

3. Prioritizing

The goal on defense is to Stop The Other Team From Scoring!! Scouting gives you hints on how to do this.

Stevens preaches “regenerative leadership” as in having older players spread the culture to the younger players and the younger players doing the same when they become the elder statesmen.

4. Awareness

Stevens believes that awareness is a big part of defense and can help a marginal athlete to become a very good defender – more so than a great athlete with marginal awareness – which I completely agree with.

He has four levels of competency.

Unconsciously Incompetent – You don’t know what you don’t know.

Consciously Incompetent – You know you have no clue.

Consciously Competent – You know what’s going on.

Unconsciously Competent - You begin to see things before they happen. You can rely on your habits because of how many times you’ve done it before.

When players get to this stage they should be given mature “freedom” to make reads.

Some awareness in players is natural but a lot can develop in practice, drills and habits. Another big part of awareness comes from the players who are defending or what the other team is running.

5. Execution/Technique

Execution and technique are the backbones of any good defense. Technique is easy to improve with individuals, the execution is the difficult part.

Boxing out is all execution/technique. Players that are good at boxing out care about it and know the importance of it.

There are multiple theories of how to box out. It all depends on what you believe in. For example, you could have your less mobile players hold the box and then go after the ball and have your mobile players just hit the offensive player and then go after the ball.

As a coach, you need to be consistent in your approach and practice.

Your system must be flexible and capable of guarding everything that an offense can throw at a you.

6. Completion

In the end, it is all about “finishing” the play. You can do everything right but don’t grab the rebound or catch an errant pass. There is a good chance your opponent will capitalize on the extra opportunity.

One final important reminder: Your team is never too far away from being great, and never too far away from being bad.

A Summary: How to Build a Basketball Defensive System

<https://basketballimmersion.com/how-to-build-a-defensive-system/>

Coach Jim Boylen talks about his basketball defensive system and how to recreate an NBA defense. This defense is what they did at Michigan State and in the NBA. He hopes that after today you'll be able to take something back to your team and teach your players how to play better defense.

As NBA coach, we're always trying to find ways to become better defensively. This is because defense and rebounding wins championships.

It is proven.

Very important.

And he is very passionate about it.

Proof comes in the NBA almost every season. Three of the four conference finalist (Indiana, San Antonio and Memphis) were in the top three in defense (2012-13).

Whatever way you push the ball is how you have to set your defense:

Three Options to Force the Ball in Your Basketball Defensive System

Push the ball sideline.

Push the ball middle.

Or play the ball chest to chest (square).

For example, whatever way you force the ball determines how you play pick and roll.

If you play pick-and-roll and you force the ball down, you need to drop your big and force the ball baseline.

If you play pick-and-roll and you blitz then you need to force the ball to the middle.

So before you determine your defensive philosophy you need to determine what way you want to force the ball. Some of the decision-making is personnel driven.

If you have posts that don't move very well, you're probably better off forcing the ball down to the sideline. This allows the post to stay closer to the basket and the pick-and-roll will be pushed down.

If your posts are active, athletic and can get out and blitz the ball then you can push the ball middle. This allows the post to get out away from the basket to put more pressure on their check and the dribbler on pick-and-roll.

What's the most important thing about defense? Stop the ball. The biggest problem stopping the ball defensively is players don't move their feet or understand how to slide their feet.

Stance Position = One Hand Up (Shot Challenge Hand), One Hand Out (Pass Deflection Hand)

He says a player should always have the hand out to the side you are influencing the ball too because it makes it easier to move in that direction. The defender's head should stay on the same plane. This means that the head should stay at the same level in the stance and not move up and down as a defender moves.

What is a Negative Step (5:11)? It is when your high foot moves before your lead foot on a slide. So the first goal in containing the ball is to be able to move your lead foot first in a slide. He demonstrates a sideline push stance – Inside foot to the midpoint is up, inside head shot challenge, outside hand to the ball, influencing the ball sideline. The sideline is your 6th defender and the baseline is your 7th defender.

The Mirror Drill (07:15)

The drill builds the defensive muscles and posture.

There is a leader and a follower.

Look each other in the eye.

The leader will step slide and the follower stays square and in the same plane.

A key teaching point is to point your toe in the direction you are going and to avoid negative steps.

“Defense is about a mindset, but it's also a skill. What we need to improve is our skill level.”

Shrinking the Floor Basketball Defensive System Concept

A good player to player defense at the NBA level is really a zone.

The most important person on the floor is the player with the ball.

All five players have to be locked into the ball.

The shrink starts with your gaps. He wants to shrink the gaps so there are no holes or seams to get in.

In the middle of the floor (dead middle) he wants to play the ball chest-to-chest. On the angle he wants to force middle.

Coach Boylen is a big believer in visual demonstration for your team. He suggest today's young kids learn in three ways and you must incorporate them every practice.

Total – Talk.

Kinesthetic – Touch.

Visual – Sight.

Establishing the Gap in Your Basketball Defensive System

If want to play in the gap defensively be one step off the line and two steps from your check (Communicates this as, “One, One-Two.”)

If you want to deny defensively, be two steps from your check on the line.

Move as the ball is released from the passer’s finger tips. Jump to the ball.

Communications are ball, ball, ball and help, help, help.

He argues that in the NBA players are too good to deny so he wants to keep people in front. Players shoot 60 percent at the rim and from the corner while outside the paint players shoot only 38 percent.

Basketball Defense Techniques, Tips and Strategies

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pjT5Z3fYvhA>

2-on-2 Shrink the Gap Drill (19:18)

Can do it from top to wing, top top or in different gaps.

Negaunee Drill (26:25)

3-on-3 six eye gap defense to work on the build your shrink concept.

He is building left and right help understanding.

Three defender start in the lane holding hands and move out to defensive positions on the coach's pass. He calls this, "Spraying Out."

He restricts offensive movements and attack opportunities.

On a skip move on the pass not when the ball is over your head.

Good ball pressure creates a "hump" on the ball (We call this no straight line skips – Force an Arc).

In My Opinion...

He asks the players to compete (27:05). Of course we all want this as a coach. The challenge in getting players to compete is creating conditions for them to compete.

With this being a shell drill with no live attack opportunities I feel like it would be impossible to get players to compete. Although we might spend on rotations in a shell situation when we first teach a drill, we would then make the drill live. If we put restrictions in, it would be on which offensive player can attack, or where they can attack from. After the attack, in all our drills, everything is 100% live. This is a condition for getting players to compete.

"The number one condition for getting players to compete is allowing them to."

Negaunee Drill with a Cutter (35:32)

Add a cutter who cuts through and goes opposite.

This works on recovery as the helpside is constantly moving.

4-on-4 Shell Drill (38:30)

4-on-4 pass and skip the ball.

If your check is farther from the rim, you can help more.

Recover to help, not to your check, so that you can support the on ball defender on a drive.

He emphasizes inside foot to the mid-point. Why does he want a help defender's inside foot up? If the helpside defender's inside foot is up they are closer and quicker to support.

Add one dribble towards the next man and then pass the ball to work help and recover concept (40:46)

Add an exchange on the weakside to make it more realistic.

On a baseline drive, the low player helps, the high player drops to the level of the ball (48:10)

On the second side, the top of the "I" takes first pass on a pass out of the baseline drive rotation.

The goal is to take away plays at the rim and make the offense kickout.

The development of your defense will take time initially to put in. As the season goes on you will clean up your defense and you will improve.

How to Build a Defensive System - Jim Boylen - Basketball Fundamentals

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=C0lsxZKGfEQ&feature=emb_imp_woyt

18 characteristics of a good defensive team

From Kevin Sutton, contributing writer

<https://winninghoops.com/article/characteristics-of-good-basketball-defense/>

Teams that know how to defense well and pressure opposing offenses have these 18 characteristics in common.

1. They recognize their opponent's offensive actions/tendencies while they're in the flow of the game.
2. They play defense with their voices, their eyes, their brains, their chests and their feet.



3. They are excellent in their rotations and avoid putting themselves in scramble situations. Rotations are intelligent movements in relation to the offensive players and ball movements, whereas scrambles are panic movements made in reaction to the ball movement, usually after there has been a defensive breakdown. Scrambles are inevitable, but they are diminished by executing proper rotations.
4. They are constantly communicating throughout each possession. They are active listeners as well. This brings about a high level of trust, which leads to a collective confidence.
5. They give “multiple efforts,” making it appear as if there are 10 guys on defense. Examples of “multiple effort” can be: close out on the ball and then doubling post, or closing out and taking a charge as you help your teammate that has been beaten off the dribble, or hedging on a ball screen and securing the defensive rebound.
6. They finish every stop with a rebound.
7. They defend without fouling.

8. They understand and believe that there is no such thing as “50/50 balls.” They believe that loose balls and errant passes are 100 percent theirs.
 9. They execute their coverages/slides based on the scouting report.
 10. They take pride in stopping their opponents.
 11. They wear down their opponents mentally and physically with their commitment on the defensive end.
 12. They force the offense to start farther from the basket than the offensive team wants to or is used to.
 13. They keep the ball on one side of the floor. They limit the number of times the ball is reversed, and they know that ball reversals hurt their defenses. They “load” to the ball (midline in college). Loading is a term used to describe the actions of the help-side defenders. Loading also helps to shrink the floor, limiting the operating area for which the offense has to work.
 14. They do not allow “paint touches.” They know it hurts their defenses.
 15. They are very good in their late shot-clock defense. They are disciplined to complete the stop, and they are calm while communication increases.
 16. They don’t give up transition baskets. They understand and execute the four parts of transition defense: Sprint back with their chins on their shoulders; locate and get the ball controlled; communicate to “load” the ball; and run down rebounds.
 17. They play with their hands up. Average defensive teams play with their hands out, while bad defensive teams play with their hands down.
 18. They develop and chart stats that reinforce the most important elements of their defensive philosophy. These stats are talked about constantly with players and visible for the players to see and embrace their importance.
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Kevin Sutton was most recently an assistant men’s basketball coach at the University of Pittsburgh. He’s also a member of the Winning Hoops Editorial Advisory Board.

http://blueprintbasketball.com/wp-content/uploads/2013/10/Mike_Dunlap_Defensive_Philosophy.pdf

<https://www.kosarkarski-trenerji.com/ftp/fiba/a28.pdf>

<http://coachjacksonspages.com/Sumner%20Defense..Do%20What%20We%20Do.pdf>

The Ultimate Basketball Team Defense

<https://basketballhq.com/basketball-team-defense>

This article was written by University of Tennessee Martin assistant men's basketball coach Jermaine Johnson.

Basketball Team Defense Introduction

Over the past several years, our basketball program has begun to notice that most offensive actions include only two or three offensive players in any play. However, we believe that five committed defensive players can consistently beat two or three offensive players if they are willing to work together as a team.

The second major concept of our philosophy as a team is to take all the guesswork out of our defense. We dictate where we will allow the offense to go and then try to take the offensive movement away.

Third, we work at being in better condition than our opponents. Our players are made to believe that they are in better shape, both mentally and physically, than our opponents.

Fourth, defense starts on offense. Our players will not be careless ball handlers on offense, and we will do an adequate job defending against any stolen pass.

In this defensive basketball article, I will share some keys to a great team defense with you, which will hopefully help you improve your team's defense! Here are the four areas that will be covered.

Defensive Philosophy

Defensive Goals

Rules for Defense

Implementing a Defensive System in Practice

Defensive Basketball Philosophy

I am a firm believer that defense truly puts your team in a position to win games and eventually championships. From your defense, you can do several positive things, such as:

Teamwork—everyone must do his job

Create offense from your defense

Make every offense trip a tough trip

Every player must give 100% effort ALL of the time

Defensive Basketball Must-Haves

1. 5 ON DEFENSE VS THE BALL
2. PLAY THE BALL AND SEE YOUR MAN
3. CONSTANT BALL PRESSURE (PRESSURE/FORCE/CONTAIN)
4. PACK IT IN TO PREVENT PENETRATING DRIVES, CUTTERS, PASSES, AND REBOUNDING
5. FORCE EVERYTHING BELOW THE FOUL LINE TO THE MIDDLE
6. FORCE EVERYTHING ABOVE THE FOUL LINE TO THE OUTSIDE
7. MOVE AS THE BALL MOVES. ROTATE IN ALL HELP SITUATIONS
8. SHRINK TO THE BALL MENTALITY (ON THE FLOOR OR ON THE GROUND)
9. ALL DEFENSIVE STOPS END WITH A DEFENSIVE REBOUND

Defensive Basketball Goals

Your goals are measuring tools to help motivate your team. The team should always be striving to reach the team's defensive goals. These goals should be adjustable as the season progresses. The goals must also be adjusted per the game plan that will be implemented for each game.

Your defensive goals should be visible for the team to see. Coaches should chart the goals as statistics and talk about them at the right moments during a game or practice.

Example of Team Defensive Basketball Goals:

1. Hold opponents to 50 points or less
2. Hold opponents to 40% or less from 2pt fg%

3. Hold opponents to 30% or less from 3 pt. fg%
4. Limit opponents Free Throw attempts to 10 or less per game
5. Avg. 25-30 Deflections per game
6. Avg. 8-10 Steals per game
7. Take 6 charges per game
8. NO TRANSITION BASKETS
9. Hold opponents to 20 dribble paint touches per game
10. Out Rebound and commit fewer fouls than the other team

Defensive Basketball Rules

The first principle in teaching this defense is to Divide the court into HELP-SIDE AND BALL SIDE:

Ball Side Rules

Always keep pressure on the ball

Make it tough to make a penetrating pass

Help and rotate

When your man passes the ball, jump to the ball

Help-Side Rules

The further your man is from the ball, the further you play from your man

When your man is above the foul line, you are one step off the line of your man and the ball and one step to the man side

Front every cutter going to the basket

The second principle is to divide the court into post responsibilities and guard responsibilities: Basically, this is why we switch the guard to forward cross. We always want big men where they are more effective. They are better rebounders, better defensively under the basket, and better at defending the forward and post area.

On the other hand, the guards/wings do a better job defending out away from the basket, and they cover more area quicker. We only switch on crosses or when the post players are close enough to switch effectively verbally.

Defensive Basketball Drills to Teach

Playing Angry Defensive Basketball Series

Post defense

Gap position

High hip closeouts

One on one sideline alleys

Disadvantage Basketball Drills

All of these basketball drills will teach your players to compete and battle. This is important because not every defensive possession goes as planned, and players must figure it out and still get a stop.

One offensive player vs. two defenders (working on trapping)

Four offensive players vs. three defenders (working on rotations)

Five offensive players vs. four defenders

Six offensive players vs. five defenders

Closeout Basketball Drills – John Cheney Series:

Basic slides.

High/Low cross closeouts

High/Low cross closeouts with a dribble

High/Low cross closeouts with post feed

In all of these basketball drills, we are working on:

Communication

Sprinting to the ball

Rotations-Drawing the charge

Building swagger and trust in our team defense

Recommended: Defensive Basketball Drills

Implementing a Defensive System in Practice:

I teach using the WHOLE/PART/WHOLE Method

Practices are broken down into 8-10 minute blocks

I use the station format as often as I can, depending on the number of assistant coaches at practice

The Ultimate Basketball Team Defense Conclusion

Must have pressure on the man with the ball. The first consideration of every player is to stop the ball with gap protection and rotation principle. Each player must feel a deep responsibility to do everything possible to keep the other team from scoring. This is the team basketball defense principle. The return will come in the form of more wins and DEFINITELY championships. DEFEND TO WIN!

BASKETBALL DEFENSIVE SYSTEMS

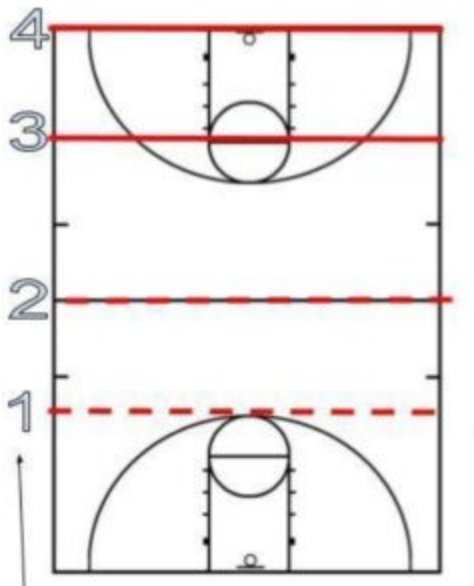
by [Coach Collins](#) | Jul 22, 2021 | [Defense](#), [Practice](#) | [0 comments](#)

<https://teachhoops.com/basketball-defensive-systems/>

Developing basketball defensive systems stands as one of the most important aspects for any coach out there. While designing offensive plays might be more fun, crafting the right defensive system might make more a difference between winning and losing. A good defense feeds directly into offense and it makes scoring that much easier.

Many coaches believe it's better to sport a simple offense and complex defense, rather than the other way around. How a coach crafts their team's defensive approach often dictates the very identity of the team. Also, not all players, particularly at the youth level, will have the same natural abilities on the offensive end, but most players can be taught complex defensive schemes and excel.

BASKETBALL DEFENSIVE SYSTEMS



One [key consideration for any coach](#), when creating their basketball defensive systems, should be the capability of the team. Depending upon the skill level of the players, a coach needs to

adapt their system to fit what the team can actually do. The system itself becomes the terminology the coach decides upon, and what each call represents for the players on the floor.

One particularly useful approach when designing a defensive system is to divide the court into quarters. “Four” represents full court. “Three” represents three-quarter court. “Two” represents half court. And “One” represents the three-point line.

Dividing the court in this way allows for the defensive system to have clear calls from the sideline. This concept is also very simple for players to understand.

From there, a coach needs to decide what defensive approaches are best suited for the team.

BASKETBALL DEFENSIVE SYSTEMS OPTIONALITY

What makes a defense complex isn’t the core concept itself, but the constant variations. If a team were to run the same base defense through each possession, it’s only a matter of time before the opposing offense feels comfortable and adjusts. This is increasingly true as the competition improves.

So when a coach decides upon their defensive approaches, most will settle on a base defense, but also install variations and special attacks. For example, a team’s base defense might be man-to-man, but a coach will also install a half court zone, as well as some sort of press. Some coaches layer multiple defensive approaches as a season progresses.

	Red	Blue	Green	Yellow
	<i>M2M</i>	<i>Even Zones</i>	<i>Odd Zones</i>	<i>Combo</i>
4	Full Court Press Full Denial	2-1-2 Press	Diamond Press	
3	¾ Quarters allow ball in.			
2	M2M at Half Court			Diamond 1 Triangle 2 (Coach calls the face guard)
1	Pick- Up at 3pt Line	2-3 Zone	3-2 Zone	1-3-1 Zone

Once the base defenses are installed, players run through the different progressions to understand the key principals. A coach will have a man-to-man defense, then perhaps zones with even fronts and odd fronts. Players practice with each approach and learn the specific terminology. From there, it's a matter of bringing the system together.

The calls from the sideline would [combine the defensive](#) approach and the pickup point. So one call might be: "Red 4" which would signal to the players a full court, man-to-man press. Another call might be "Blue 2", which would be a half court, 2-3 zone.

Coaches can play with the terminology and defensive approaches, but the optionality is what makes these basketball defensive systems complex. Constant changes frustrate opposing offenses and create opportunities for the defenses.

RELATED: [*4-ON-4 CUT THROAT BASKETBALL PRACTICE PROGRESSION*](#)

RESOURCES:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rGVa-3TenSE>

How to Coach Basketball Individual and Team Defense

<http://www.guidetocoachingbasketball.com/team%20defense.htm>

In my 77 years of observing basketball at all levels of play, I have found that every great championship team was strong defensively. It has also been my observation that no matter how good the offense becomes, there will be days when the lid is on the basket, but good defenders seem to never have off nights.

Good basic basketball defense does require speed and quickness; however, I have often seen players make up for these physical shortcomings by out-hustling and developing a defensive attitude that is aggressive. It isn't necessary that a player be highly skilled to play effective, hard-nosed defense.

Too many athletes get the idea that defense is passive. Passivity creates negative actions. Aggressiveness is positive. I think you will find that all aggressive minded athletes will be the best defenders. Even while defending a goal, players should always be on attack.

Most important is the fact that anyone through hard work, and attention to detail, learn to play good solid defense. It is a known fact in the basketball coaching circle that a player can learn basic defensive skills far quicker than he can learn to properly execute basic offensive skills. On defense, hustle, aggressiveness, and anticipation tend to make up for other deficiencies in a player's game.

The great defensive performer is ready to start guarding his man when he comes out of his dressing room, guard him if he goes into the popcorn stand, and until the final whistle. The opponent should go home with the feeling of being attacked by a wild octopus. He should have nightmares dreaming about the aggressive tactics that wild man inflicted, not giving him one minute of peace.

The current trend is toward defense. Never before, in the history of the game has defense been played as currently being played by the top teams in the NCAA. No team has a corner on the defensive game, today. All good teams are playing it more efficiently each year. The trend is pointing in that direction out of necessity. More time must be devoted in preparation of a way to stop modern offensive formations and patterns. Younger coaches are discovering something that Bob Knight and Dean Smith have known for years and always practiced.

In most cases the defender positions himself either between his man and the basket, particularly if guarding a player with the ball, or partially or wholly between his man and the ball. Both positions serve to reduce the action-reaction advantage favoring the offensive player, forcing the offensive player to work harder than normal to get the ball or move into scoring position.

Individual Requirements

Defensive team play can only be as effective as the individual ability and dedication of each player. Attributes to be sought individually are:

Desire and Pride. Regardless of how sound a player is fundamentally, he can not be an effective defender if he lacks either these two qualities. Playing hard-nosed defense requires hard work and determination, while offering little praise or recognition. Hustle is the child of desire that includes determination to play defense well. A good defender works tirelessly and puts forth that extra effort even when tired. Pride is the satisfaction one feels when knowing he played the part to the best of his ability while receiving little, or no credit.

Mental Alertness and Aggressiveness. The player who reacts immediately from offense to defense will be in position to cover unguarded opponents, prevent the surprise offensive maneuver, putting the offense at a disadvantage. These two requirements can often force an opponent into a defensive posture even though he has control of the ball.

Anticipation and Adaptability. Anticipation is the ability to predetermine offensive patterns. To decide whether a pass can be intercepted or change offensive men with a teammate before the situation presents itself. Adjusting to changes with the correct defensive action indicates a player's adaptability. This is not based entirely on instinct, but upon an intelligent study of an opponent's individual and team offensive moves from the moment the game began.

Speed and Quickness. Running speed enables a defender to move from one court position to another more quickly than other players. His speed and quickness allows him to recover from defensive mistakes, assuming a new defensive position with little danger to the team. Quickness of feet, hands, and arms enables a defender to keep the offense in a protective attitude by individual harassment. Quickness effectively neutralizes an opponent's superior speed. Because the normal defensive distance from the basket is between eighteen and twenty -two feet, quickness is probably a bigger asset than speed.

The objective of a **basketball team defense** is to stop the offensive team from scoring. We all know this is an impossible task. More practical is the attempt to take the opponent out of the offense they are trying to run. This can be done by:

Forcing the ball toward low-percentage shooters, or scoring areas by fronting or overplaying the opponent's high scorer.

Getting back quickly on defense to limit the fast-break opportunities

Forcing shooters to alter their position, timing, release, or arc of their shot

From the above, you can see the entire purpose of a team's defense is to limit the opponent's opportunity to score by these three things. The **coach** must use several factors, the most important one is the available personnel.

It is my opinion the correct defense is one which limits the opponent's offensive attacks. A good team defense, this day and age, incorporates the strong points of both the zone and man-to-man defense. The primary focus in a man-to-man is the person and the secondary objective is the ball; however, teams that use person-to-person as a primary defense also use some zone principles as playing loosely away from the ball. They collapse weak-side toward the basket to prevent penetration, compacting the defense in the basket area.

Conversely, zone defensive players play the ball first and the person second, but must be able to defend against the opponent with the ball on a person-to-person basis.

In the old days, a zone player covered a specific area. It isn't that way, today. Zones of today, flex with a person-to-person attitude at the ball, attacking the person with the ball and preventing a pass into the pivot.

Whatever Defensive You Choose

Insist that players never allow the offensive team to advance the ball to their point of attack without strong defensive pressure.

As a coach do not use a single defense in your overall preparation.

Adapt to whatever defensive style is best suited to counteract the opponent's offensive moves.

Understand the type of defense you choose to use and be able to teach it to your players.

Work hard at improving your team's defense. Any defense used must be:

Sound, both individually and as a team.

Flexible, adaptable to different offensive attacks

Simple, enough for your players to learn.

Complex, for the opponent's to solve.

Defensive ability is based on the following factors:

Hard work.

Determination.

Dedication.

Discipline.

Concentration.

Responsibility.

Cooperation.

Physical and mental coordination.

Speed and quickness.

Willingness.

Pride.

When coaches scout their opponents, they preview each other's defenses. Showing multiple defenses allows a coach to employ a defense that will give his opponent difficulty. This forces the opposing coach to use practice time to prepare for each defense playing against reserve players who must be taught each defense in order to act as opponents.

A good coach should pressure teams holding the ball for a last shot at the end of a period or the game. The stalling team generally are so interested in maintaining possession, they usually do not look at the basket; therefore, it might be easy to force them into a violation. Teams who are ahead should not relax and become passive either on offense or defense.

All teams must be able to press to some degree, especially in the late stages of a game. Defensive aggressiveness will cause the opponents to move out of their normal pattern.

Defensively, a team should change the game pace to its own advantage. You must surprise and confuse the opponent. Saving some practiced defensive variations for the second half that were not shown in the first half is generally another good surprise maneuver. You could also use a defensive variation in the last few minutes of the first half so that the opposing coach will use much of his valuable half-time period discussing methods of attacking a defense that will not be used again in that game.

The winning team in basketball is frequently the team quickest in transition from offense to defense; therefore, it is important that your team maintains defensive balance while attacking offensively. You must always keep a player in a defensive safety position so that he may hinder, or stop, the opponents from scoring an easy unopposed basket. A team should have:

Three offensive rebounders.

One person who is half offensive and half defensive, going to the ball only if certain of possession.

One player at Safety Defensive position.

Preparation

Defensive preparation begins the first day. Team defensive fundamentals are essential and should be reviewed throughout the season.

You must practice double-teaming opponents, working on the double-teaming aspects from person-to-person, zone, or zone-press defensive alignments. You must teach baseline defensive techniques and how to play persons who do not have possession of the ball. If you want an

aggressive defense, you must have your players to overplay. If not, let them play loose or sag back when the player is one pass away. It is best that you teach all your players to never allow an opponent to cut in front of them to the ball, especially a corner player who wants to cut to the keyhole area with the ball out front or on the opposite side.

Emphasize the need for a good defense by doing as follows:

Insist upon attention to detail when implementing the defensive.

Break the defense into fundamental parts.

Practice group defensive techniques each session.

Develop rules for each phase of the defense.

Spread defensive drills discriminately through daily practice. For example: at the beginning of one practice session, halfway through another, and at the end on the third day.

Never allow improper defense by any player. Correct poor procedure immediately.

Reward good defensive play. Give praise both public and private for outstanding defensive accomplishment.

Determining Team Defense

The basic makeup of your material must be considered. In general, a team will consist of one of the following groups:

Five taller than average players - If you choose a person-to-person defense, it should be a loose defense. If the coach prefers a zone, a passive type might be best. In this type of defense your players can defend the goal area. Whenever pressure is needed, a type of half-court pressure should do the job. Have your quickest player force the ball up to the mid-court line and the entire team giving pressure in the half-court area.

Four tall players and one small and quick player - Teach this group a loose person to person defense or a one-two-two zone where the smaller and quicker player is given freedom to anticipate and intercept. Whenever pressure is needed, a type of half-court pressure is best, with the small player forcing the ball up to the mid-court line and the entire team exerting pressure in the half-court area.

Three tall players and two smaller players - I recommend a regular person-to-person defense. The team could also use a two-one-two or a two-three zone, a combination defense, or a pressure defense that could be extended to a two-two-one full-court pressure.

Two tall players and three small players - You can use any type of person-to-person defense. You could use a three-two zone, a one-two-two zone, a one-three-one zone, or a combination defense. Whenever a pressure defense is needed, this team can use any type pressure defense, be it half-court, three-quarter-court, or full court.

One tall player and four small players - I recommend a switching person-to-person defense whereby the four small players switch on every lateral cross or movement toward the basket, staying with their player only on diagonal cuts. The best half-court zone would be either a two-two-one or a one-three-one. Leave the big player in the basket area at all times.

Five small players - This team should use a tight person-to-person half-court defense with double or turn action taken on the outside dribbler. A full-court person-to-person would be OK, too. A zone press defense could be used, with all five players crashing the defensive boards, or an aggressive two-three zone defense in which pressure is put on the ball at all areas of the front court.

Team Principles of Basketball Defense

"All good defenses, be it person-to-person, combination. or zone, are based on these six principles:

Reduce the High-Percentage Shots.

Decrease the Number of Shots under 18 feet.

Limit you opponent's Second-Shot opportunities.

Eliminate Turn-Overs.

Attack the Ball with Controlled Aggressiveness.

Discourage Opponents from Penetrating.

Let me repeat, the objective of a **basketball team defense** is to stop the offensive team from scoring; however, this is an impossible task. More practical is the attempt to take the opponent out of the offense they are trying to run and the ball out of the hands of their best scorer.

How can an aggressive defensive mindset influence team performance:

An example by Pedro Calles` Rasta Vechta (2019-2020)

https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/how-can-aggressive-defensive-mindset-influence-your-alain?trk=public_profile_article_view

Alain Philippart de Foy

Alain Philippart de Foy

Basketball Coach at ALBA Berlin

Published Nov 24, 2020

[**+ Follow**](#)

There are no absolutes in basketball. Different roads can lead to success. I had a long intro full of topics but decided to keep it straight and simple, so here are some reasons why you might want to consider working on an aggressive defensive philosophy:

-Instils a culture of effort: by repeatedly pushing the envelope you make it an habit. Sure, you might give up some easy points, but you can potentially ingrain fear in your opponent, all while creating your team identity. If you are used to making consecutive efforts, you will be ready when things get hard.

-Enhances communication: we all want our teams to talk and communicate. How we coach and train it would be a topic for a long discussion for sure. An aggressive defense pushes them to do so more efficiently because of the risks you take. A conservative defense also requires proper communication, but we could argue that it is not the same to communicate under a rushing pressure than in a more controlled setting.

-Keeps you on attack mode: one could argue that playing an aggressive defense keeps you in control, but that would be a lie. Playing properly a more conservative defense would also have you in control if you get the opponent to play by your rules. What I like about an aggressive defense is that it keeps you attacking, not waiting for the offense to make a mistake, but pushing them to do so.

-Energizes players and crowd: few things in basketball bring out the best of the crowd like a hustle play. A deflection, a dive for the ball, an offensive charge...all of them have the same, if not better, effect than a long distance three or a poster dunk. Sure, talent is needed for the offensive and defensive highlights, but in the latter, effort can make up for a big part.

Now that we went through the theory lets take a look at some visual examples by a, by all means, overachieving team of the past two easy Credit BBL seasons, RASTA Vechta, then coached by Pedro Calles who now is at the Hamburg Towers. RASTA took the league by storm and made the playoffs on their first two seasons in the BBL after returning from the Pro A and did it with a clear defined identity.

Rasta Vechta - Defense

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2ifGiH4IEHg>

Is this something you have thought about trying to instil in your teams? Do you do it already? If so, how does it work so far? Or do you prefer to take a different approach? Happy to hear your thoughts!

WEAK HAND DEFENSIVE PHILOSOPHY...

<HTTPS://WWW.TEAMARETE.NET/BLOOD-BLOG/WEAK-HAND-DEFENSIVE-PHILOSOPHY>

7/8/2021

0 Comments



This weeks Blood Blog we are sharing our "**Weak Hand**" defensive philosophy. Take a look at it, we modified what Coach Dave Smart from Carleton University has done. At the HS level this is game changing.

WEAK HAND DEFENSE

“0” defense

<https://docs.google.com/document/d/1xQYKx-E0jowMefPH2fDeq9kvfKSk2hNT5yyONSwAs90/edit>

Our Defense: Man to Man Defense that is Weak Hand driven.

Belief: Most Players are not as good scoring with their non-dominant hand, but our main reason we do this is not about scoring it's about passing. Shooting % goes way down when passes are not on target and on time. (*analytics prove*)

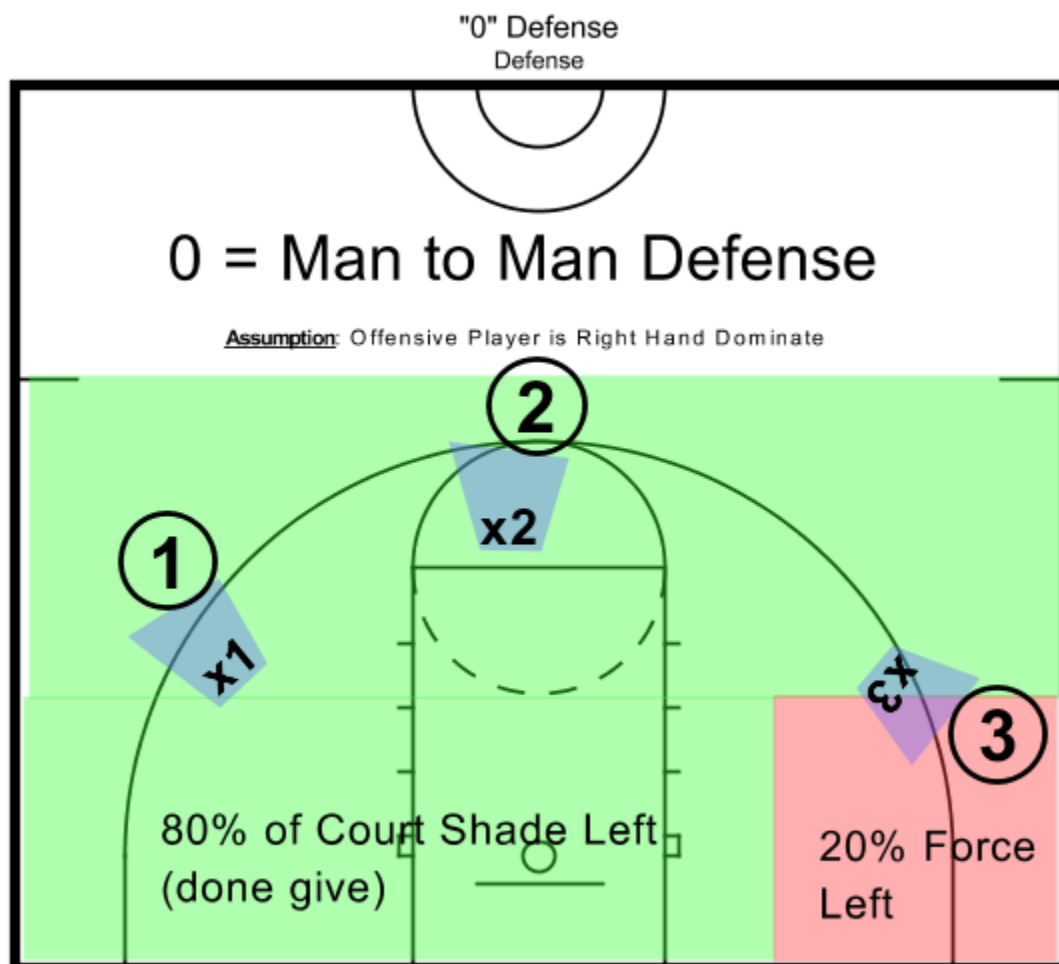
On Ball Calls:

“Weak” = Match-up is even. Normal Situation

“Dead” = Don’t need any help. Deny all passing options

“Early” = Best Player or Bad Match-Up. 4 guys squeezing to help

“Late” = vs a smaller pass first guard.



Everytime the ball is put on the floor

5 guys have to be guarding the BALL

Bluffing or Helping

Most of the time **Short Closeout = Bluff**, **Long Closeout = Help**

(Short Closeouts) On Ball Defender

Assuming we are guarding a player that is right hand dominant.

Play straight up and shade to the left on 80% of the Court

Force to left on 20% of the Court

Off Ball Defenders use Packline Principles

(Long Closeouts) On Ball Defender

Only on Shooters! Short Closeout if non shooter.

Change the angle and get to shooting hand, make put down with left.

He cannot have the option of going two ways **FORCE WEAK**

Everyone on the team knows where he is going on drive

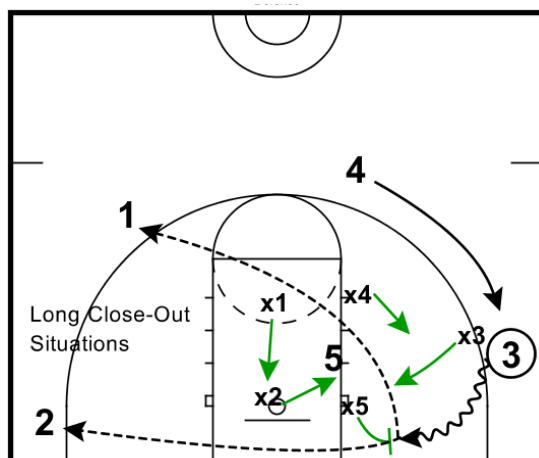
Make them go where we want them to go

On a blow by **“HELP”** is called by the next defender and he Takes Ball

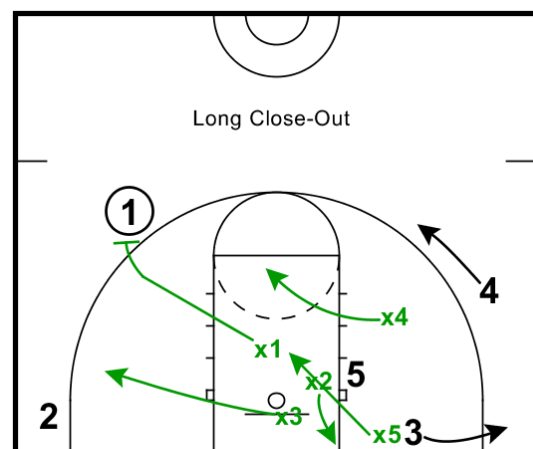
He is asking for the next guy to help him. This guy has **“2”**

Defender that was beat on blow by rotates to open player.

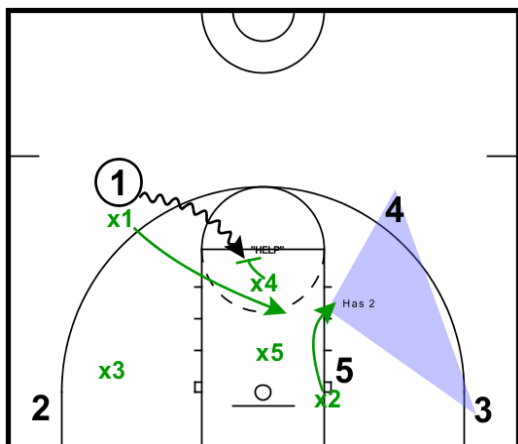
Example: Long Closeout



X1 must make him put on floor weak



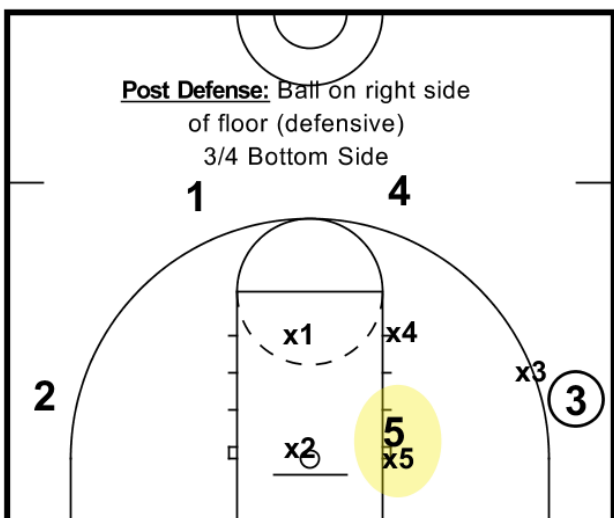
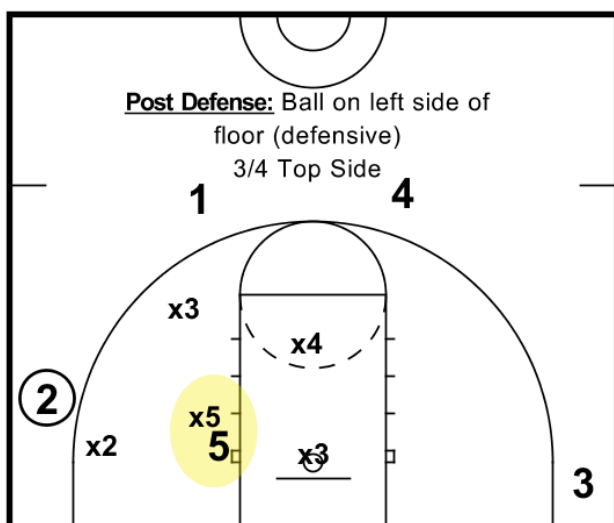
X4 makes “Help” call on blow by



Post Defense:

Left Side of Floor

Right Side of Floor



Ball Screen Coverage:

We must Bully the Point of Attack! Post yells **“Screen”** until he sees Guard change his feet. Guard has to call **“Good”** when he is good. Do not run into screens!

“Show” Post shows, Guard goes over screen

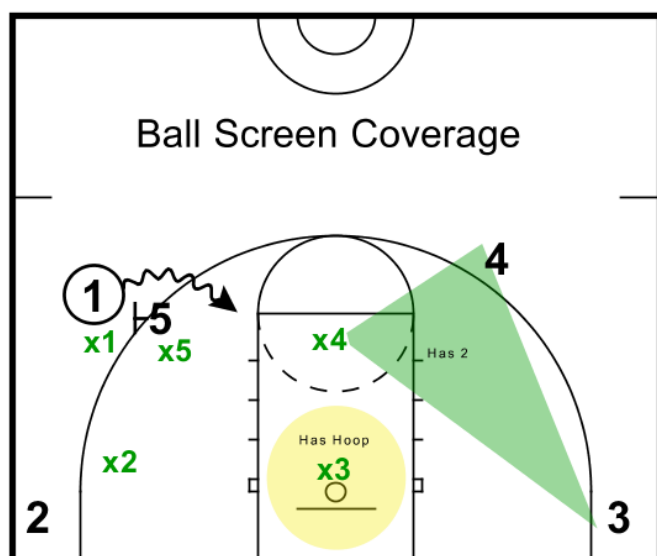
“Shock” Post hides and Jumps out daring off to split, Guard goes under

“Ice” Post GuideLines it, Guard Bullies it to Weak Hand

“Blitz” Double the Ball, we can “Attack” or “Contain” it

“Wait” Post on FT Line, Guard goes over. (post cannot show or shock well)

“Switch” Post still hit, then back up and guard, Guard goes under



Maurice Joseph - Team Defense Philosophy and Ball Screen Coverage

1,036 views

Jul 11, 2020

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QDYm_hKPrN4

Teaching Your Defensive Philosophy

<https://coachingtoolbox.net/teaching-your-defensive-philosophy>

This post was submitted by Coach Tom Kelsey. Coach Kelsey has been a Head Coach at Belhaven University, Faulkner University, and Greater Atlanta Christian High School. He has also been an assistant at LSU, Alabama, Murray State, and Lipscomb. He played at Lipscomb under Coach Don Meyer.

Does your team have a defensive identity?

Do your players know what you want on the defensive end of the floor?

Can you quickly state what you want your team to be known for on the defensively?

What defensive concepts will help put your team in the best position to win your league?

All these questions you need to answer when putting together your defensive philosophy.

Taking ideas from years of coaching and [finding how respected coaches teach their teams](#).

Here is a list I have used with my teams and it helps remind me as a coach the areas we need to concentrate on for each game and practice.

Defensive Philosophy

1. Transition

As soon as the ball changes hands (made shot, missed shot, turnover) we are sprinting back to half court to pick up our defensive assignment. Whether man or zone, we make every defensive transition a sprint to half court. Once we get to half court, our next immediate job is to find the person we are guarding. If we are in a zone, our job is to pick up shooters in our defensive area.

2. Stop the Ball

It is the point guard's responsibility to stop the ball from getting into a penetration area (inside the three-point area). Off the break, we are going to keep our opponent outside the three-point line.

3. Pressure the Ball

Once a team enters into their offensive set or motion offense, we will keep an extreme amount of pressure on the basketball. We do not want the offensive at any time to be able to pick apart our defense. Point guards will pick up the ball from the half court area and all other players are to keep pressure on their man if they have the ball within 25 feet of the basket.

4. Contain the Dribble

Players will keep the ball in front of them. Containing the dribble is a key component to us having success on the defensive end of the floor. We have to each be able to contain the dribble by being aware of how close we can guard the offensive player.

5. Deny the next penetrating pass

We will have a hand in the passing lane when the player we are guarding is the next possible receiver and they are a penetrating pass away. Our goal is to deny each penetrating pass for the player with the ball.

6. Helpside defense

Our ball side defense will make us tough and our help side defense will make us great. Our defense each possession is a team defense. We have a particular player to guard, but we will guard them as a team. Each player must be ready and willing to rotate spots as the ball changes positions on the floor. We will not allow easy drives to the basket in our half-court defense.

7. Fronting the Post

We teach each post player to defend the post. When the ball is above the baseline, we will front on the high side. When the ball gets to the baseline, we will rotate our position and guard from the low side. We never want to be directly behind a post player unless our scouting report dictates that is the only way we can guard that particular post player.

8. Doubling the Post

We will double in the post from different areas of the floor. Depending on the player and the opposing team, we will double from different areas of the floor. We will never double the post leaving a shooter open on the floor.

9. Guarding Screens

Our way of guarding screens will vary from game to game depending on the opponent. We will start the season by not switching any screens in the post or on the perimeter that are away from the ball.

10. Guarding Ball screens

On ball screens, we will work on switching the screen, going on top of the screen and staying with our man and we will work on trapping the ball screen.

11. Closing Out

We will contest each shot taken by our opponent. Each day we will work on our closeout position and stance. We will sprint half way to the opponent then break down in a defensive stance using short chopping steps to closeout. Our weight will be back and our hands will always be up with one hand contesting the shot. We will leave our feet each time to closeout on the shot.

12. Block out and Rebound

We take pride in making sure to have a good block out each time an opponent takes a shot from the field or free throw line. Our goal is to give our opponent only one shot each time they come down the floor. Once the ball comes off the rim or backboard, we want to put the basketball under the chin with our elbows out.

Sunmer Spartan
Basketball Defensive philosophy

<http://coachjacksonspages.com/Sumner%20Defense..Do%20What%20We%20Do.pdf>

Basketball Defenses - Selecting Your Half-Court Defense(s)

By Dr. James Gels, from the Coach's Clipboard Basketball Playbook

<https://www.coachesclipboard.net/BasketballDefenses.html>

Categories of Half-Court Defenses:

- Man-to-man defenses
- Zone defenses
- Combination "junk" defenses
- Half-court presses and traps
- Defending inbounds plays
- Press Defenses

Select a basketball defense(s) that fits your team's personnel, size, quickness, strengths, and your defensive philosophy. Some coaches simplify and stick to the same defense all season and try to perfect it. Other coaches will try multiple defenses switching between man-to-man and zone defenses, hoping to confuse the opponent and counter their strengths.

I have seen coaches go man-to-man anytime the point guard made the first pass to the right side, and go 2-3 zone whenever that first pass went to the left side. Some coaches will change defenses after a made free-throw, or after a time-out, or will call out defenses from the sideline. The main thing... in trying to confuse the offense, make sure your own players aren't the ones who become confused!

Man-to-Man Defense

Man-to-man defense has each defender assigned to defend a certain offensive player - his or her "man". Sounds simple enough, but great man-to-man defense is much more than that.



On-ball defenders contain the ball while adjacent defenders "hedge" in the seams to stop dribble-penetration. Defenders two-passes away from the ball drop off their man into "helpside" defense. So away from the ball, man-to-man defense looks a lot like a zone defense, while you have a defender pressuring the ball. If your players are less athletic, consider the "pack line" defense.

My personal belief is that all young players MUST learn how to play man-to-man defense. Even high school teams that play zone defense will be stronger defensively if every player can play pressure, on-ball defense. Understanding helpside defensive principles makes learning zone rotations easy for most players. See: ["Teaching Basketball by Progression"](#).

[Man-to-Man Pressure Defense...](#) this article has everything required for man-to-man "team" defense... on-ball pressure, deny, helpside, preventing dribble-penetration, defending the post, cutters, screens and out-of-bounds plays. Two trapping tactics ("Red" and "Side-Fist") are also presented. The animation is very helpful.

[Basic Man-to-Man Defense...](#) the basic principles.

[Pack Line Defense...](#) a sagging man-to-man defense that helps protect the paint and deny dribble-penetration.

Bob Kloppenburg's SOS Pressure Defense - 3-part series:

[Overview of the SOS Pressure Defense](#) - an overview of the SOS defense from legendary NBA coach Bob Kloppenburg.

[Bob Kloppenburg's Half-Court SOS Pressure Defense](#) - details of the half-court SOS pressure defense.
[Bob Kloppenburg's Full-Court SOS Pressure Defense](#) - SOS defense - transition and full-court.

[Defense for the Last Few Seconds of the Game...](#) defensive strategies for the end of a close game.

[Defending Screens...](#) over, under and ice techniques vs on-ball screen. Also inside post screens, lateral screens, down-screens, back-screens, etc.

[Defending the Pick and Roll...](#) from Coach Joao Costa.

[Defending Without Fouling...](#) become a disciplined team that doesn't foul.

[Defensive Tips...](#) basics for players.

[Defensive Intensity.](#) Turn up your defensive intensity by [Charting Deflections](#).

Drills for Teaching Man-to-Man Defense:

[Breakdown Drills for Teaching M2M Defense...](#) breakdown drills for teaching man-to-man pressure defense.

[Shell Drill...](#) helpside, deny, hedge, on-ball positioning.

[M2M Positioning Drill...](#) helpside, deny, on-ball positioning.

[Defense 1-on-1 Drills...](#) defending 1-on-1, on-ball defense.

[Defensive Close-Outs and Drills...](#) how to close-out on the ball.

[Trapping Drills...](#) learn to trap.

[Take the Charge Drill...](#) rotate and take the charge.

[3-on-3 Competitive Defensive Drill...](#) improve your team's intensity.

Zone Defense

Zone defense differs from man-to-man defense in that, instead of guarding a particular player, each zone defender is responsible for guarding an area of the floor, or "zone", and any offensive player that comes into that area. Zone defenders move their position on the floor in relationship to where the ball moves.

There are advantages and disadvantages. You can often stop dribble-penetration and protect the paint with a 2-3 zone, but you'll get less pressure on the outside. See "[Zone Defense](#)" for details. Zone defenses can be categorized based on the defensive set that you use (2-3, 1-2-2, 3-2, 1-3-1, etc). [Rebounding out of a zone defense](#) is also important.

Specific Zone Defenses

2-3 Zone Defense... protect the paint and stop dribble-penetration. But watch out for those outside shooters. You can play a sagging type of 2-3 zone, or a more aggressive, trapping 2-3 zone.

Coach Marshall's 2-3 Zone Defense... over 40 years of success and knowledge go into this 2-3 zone defense.

Dave Robbins Circle Defense... Coach Dave Robbins' Circle zone defense (2-3 and 1-2-2 zones).

Buzz, Twilight Zone Defense... a novel way of playing the 2-3 zone defense by playing in the passing lanes.

1-2-2 and 3-2 Zone Defenses... with the 1-2-2, pressure the ball on the outside arc, allow for some trapping, but you leave the high post, middle of the paint, and corners open. Close the high post by adjusting and switching to a 3-2 zone.

1-3-1 Zone Defense... apply pressure on the outside arc and high post, and allow for some trapping, but you are vulnerable inside and in the corners. Two styles are presented, a conventional more conservative zone, and a more aggressive, trapping style.>

Amoeba Defense... a gambling, surprise tactic zone defense.

SWARM Defense... ball pressure, stopping the dribble, circle rotation from coach Wayne Walters.

Point-Zone Defense... pressure the ball, protect the paint, confuse the offense.

Defense for the Last Few Seconds of the Game... defensive strategies for the end of a close game.

Match-up Zone and Combination "Junk" Defenses

Match-up zone is a "combination" defense, combining elements of man-to-man defense (on-ball), and zone defense (away from the ball). This is a zone defense that acts a lot like a man-to-man defense.



The on-ball defender closes-out and pressures the ball. The zone away from the ball resembles man-to-man "help-side" defense. Match-up zones have specific rotations and assignment rules. You can confuse the offense by changing your starting defensive set. The opponent may be unable to determine if you are in a man or zone defense.

"Junk" defenses are defenses designed for special situations, and you would never base your entire season's defensive scheme on junk defenses. But they can be helpful in certain situations. Defending a team with superior talent or a star player is always a challenge, and a junk defense may help. Some of these defenses include the "triangle defense", the "box-and-1", "diamond-and-1", "triangle-and-2", "inverted triangle-and-2", "1-3 and a chaser", and "3-1 and a chaser".

Combination Zone Defenses

Match-up Zone Defense... important principles, rules, different sets.

1-3-1 Match-up Zone Defenses... a detailed 1-3-1 match-up zone from Coach Ken Sartini.

Junk Defenses... defending the star player, "box-and-1", "diamond-and-1", "triangle-and-2", "inverted triangle-and-2", "1-3 and a chaser", and "3-1 and a chaser".

4-1 Chameleon Defense... unusual 4-1 half-court defense from Tyler Whitcomb.

Triangle Defense... a defense for defending a star perimeter player.

Half-Court Press Defense, Traps

Starting your defense at (or just beyond) the half-court line can confuse the offense, result in turnovers, steals and lay-ups in transition. It can disrupt the normal flow of the offense, making it difficult for them to get into their offense. Any press is a gamble that you might give up an easy basket, but half-court presses are less risky than full-court presses since you have all five defenders back in the half-court.

Some teams half-court press the entire game, or until the offense shows they can beat it. Some teams use it intermittently, as a surprise tactic.

Additionally, within in the framework of our basic man-to-man pressure defense, we will at times "Red" (aggressively trap) the point guard O1 as he/she comes across half-court, or after our point defender forces O1 to one side, or on an on-ball screen, or whenever O1 is dribbling too much.

Half-Court Zone Press Defense.

Viking 1-2-2 Half-Court Press... a very effective 1/2 to 3/4 court trapping press if you have three quick athletes (X1, X2 and X3) who play aggressively.

2-2-1 Half-Court Press... another half-court trapping press defense.

Defending Out-of-Bounds Plays

Choose between man-to-man or a zone defense in defending out-of-bounds plays. Some teams simply defend all baseline out-of-bounds plays with a 2-3 zone. This packs the paint area, and will help nullify screens and prevent inside lay-ups. However, there are inbounds plays designed to attack the 2-3 zone (see "Out-of-Bounds Plays vs the 2-3 Zone")

Using man-to-man defense, we have several rules. First, "step under" and switch any inside screens. The screened defender steps under (back toward the baseline one step) to get inside position on the screener, in order to avoid getting pinned. In addition, deny the pass inside by having your inbounds defender play a "one-man zone" off the ball in the paint. The inbound defender drops off the inbound passer into the paint, looking to deny any pass inside and lay-up. Once the pass goes outside, he/she must go quickly with his man, the inbounder. See Defending Baseline Out-of-Bounds Plays.

Southern embracing defensive philosophy on basketball court

By **Mark Zimmario** -

January 7, 2022

<https://southphillyreview.com/2022/01/07/southern-embracing-defensive-philosophy-on-basketball-court/>

Jabree Coleman and Nasir Ralph took different paths and have different ways of helping the South Philadelphia High School boys basketball team. But they can both agree that defense always comes first.

The two Southern seniors are making huge plays at one end of the court, leading to a happy group of scorers at the other end.

“I try to tell them that defense translates to offense,” Southern coach Thomas Terry said. “In this day and age, everybody wants to play offense. Nobody wants to play defense. But if the other team can’t score, they can’t win. I don’t care if we win 43-20. It’s still a win. Everybody wants to score 80-90 points but they’re also giving up 80-90 points. I tell the guys that as long as we play defense collectively, it will show up in the game.”



Southern basketball coach Thomas Terry gathers with his team during a timeout. Photo/Mark Zimmaro

Coleman and Ralph particularly have bought into that philosophy. Coleman has played with the Rams all four years and has stepped into a leadership role as the team's big man in the paint. Scoring a bucket can be fun. But blocking a shot is his forte.

"It feels great blocking a shot," Coleman said with a big smile. "It gives your teammates so much energy when you make a play like that. I was never really focused on scoring. I just wanted to play defense and get rebounds."

Ralph shares that same defensive passion, but he uses a different method. The speedy guard is the team leader in steals, making it a nightmare for his opponents trying to execute a pass at the top of the key. Ralph is playing his first year of high school basketball as a senior and had to work his way into the starting lineup.

"I worked really hard at it," Ralph said. "(Coach Terry) said I had to step it up because I was playing lazy. But then I just came out stealing the ball and playing as hard defense as I can."

It cemented his spot in the starting five. Terry now looks to Ralph to make a play when the team needs it most.

“Nasir is the catalyst of my defense,” Terry said. “He changes the complexion of our team. We play off that energy on defense.”



Dayon Warren (0) drives the lane and scores against Academy at Palumbo. Photo/Mark Zimmaro

Once things are settled on the back end, the Rams' big scorers Yassir Joyner, Stephen Hill and Dayon Warren go to work, filling the basket. Joyner and Warren are both averaging double-digit scoring this season as Southern has raced out to a 7-2 record through Jan. 9.

Coleman and Ralph have proven they can score, too, as each picks his spot to contribute a big basket. Coleman shined in a 69-36 victory over the Academy at Palumbo on Jan. 4, scoring 16 points while hauling in 15 rebounds.

“Not to say he’s on that level, but Jabree is our Rasheed Wallace when he was in Detroit,” Terry said. “He plays a big game.”

The offensive spark is something Coleman has been adding to his game, despite his love of denying his opponent in the defensive paint.

“Since I was younger, I always played center and big man so my game was always focused on boxing out and getting rebounds and blocks,” said Coleman, an A’s and B’s student who wants to study engineering in college. “But now I’m trying to work on my scoring a little bit. Coach has been helping me with my free throws and my footwork in the post.”

Ralph wasn’t sure what he wanted prior to senior year. But he decided to join the Rams and he’s glad he did.

“This is my first year playing,” Ralph said. “I can say it, I was bull (crap) before. But now I take it seriously. You just can’t just play and expect to be a basketball player. You can’t just play ball. You need to be a basketball player.”



Yassir Joyner listens to Southern Coach Thomas Terry before the Rams played Academy at Palumbo in boys basketball. Photo/Mark Zimmario
He found a good teacher in Terry, who has helped him grow his game.

“I had to light a fire under him and make sure he understands that he can be a top defender in the (Philadelphia) Public League,” Terry said. “You just have to believe that. If I believe it, then you have to believe it. He’s starting to believe that.”

And the Rams are starting to believe they have something special in the making.

“It’s just like baking a cake,” Terry said. “We have to make sure we put the ingredients together and it’s going to slow cook and rise. And I think we’re starting to come together as a team.”

Jeff Van Gundy's Defensive Philosophy



Written by [Coach Peterman](#)

<https://www.mensbasketballhoopscoop.com/jeff-van-gundys-defensive-philosophy/>

<https://www.box.com/s/96yhgbknttxjgh87iqye>

FIVE AREAS OF FOCUS FOR THE PRE-SEASON

<https://betterbasketball.com/five-areas-of-focus-for-the-pre-season/>

04 NOV FIVE AREAS OF FOCUS FOR THE PRE-SEASON

Posted at 07:16h in Coaching Philosophy by kyle 0 Comments

0Likes

One of the most important components to having a successful season is creating a plan for your program in the pre-season. There are endless areas of focus to plan for but the five main things that I typically like to focus on are:

Coaching roles and responsibilities

Offensive philosophy

Defensive philosophy

Rebounding philosophy

Drills for individual and team skill development

Before the start of each season it is vital to meet with your coaching staff to not only share your plan, but to also discuss and receive feedback on any additional thoughts or changes that are in the best interest of your program. Whether it is a weekend retreat to the beach or a Monday night dinner, it is extremely important that your coaches buy-in to the plan before it's conveyed to your players.

COACHING RESPONSIBILITIES

From the head coach all the way down to your last assistant (*and Director of Operations and Video Coordinators if applicable*), each coach on your staff needs to fully understand their roles and responsibilities for the season. Here are some suggestions of responsibilities to cover:

- Academic Tracking & Progress
- Practice & Game Gym Setup (Chairs, Sweeping Floors, Clocks, etc)
- Bench Duties (What is being charted/watched on the bench?)
- Community Outreach (Newsletters, Pictures, Community Service, Booster Clubs, etc)
- Strength & Conditioning
- Film (Highlight, scouting, and motivational videos)
- Guard Development (Who is mainly in charge of the guards during individual instruction)
- Post Development (Who is mainly in charge of the bigs during individual instruction)

Some may find it unusual to have a particular coach in charge of a group of players such as Guards or Bigs, but I have found it helps players by hearing the same language and

terminology every day. The goal is to keep them energized and engaged, hearing conflicting teaching points could interfere with this process.

OFFENSIVE PHILOSOPHY

The offensive philosophy should really be geared around your personnel and can change every year. For instance, if you are coaching an uptempo style of play and your team is not very gifted athletically, that may not be what is best for your team. One mistake some coaches make is they are so excited for the start of the season that they try to put in everything the first week. Focus on the foundation of your system and add to it as the season progresses. If they cannot execute Part 1, there is not reason to put in Part 2 yet. Here are some thoughts (Not in any particular order) to take into consideration when developing your offensive philosophy:

1. What pace or style of play do you want to play?
2. What pace or style of play fits your personnel?
3. Establish your fast break and press break systems
4. Consider putting in one or several [quick hitters](#) to run as [early offense](#) (ie- Pick & Rolls, Pin-Downs, Post-Up, etc)
5. Are you a [read and react team](#) or a team that runs set plays? That needs to be established early.
 - o If you are a read and react team, what layers do you want to get in the first week(s) of practice?
 - o If you are a set plays team, have your plays organized early and have a timely schedule in place of when the plays will be implemented.
6. The above also applies to Side and Underneath [Out-of-Bounds](#). Are you a “get it in” team or do you want to score out-of-bounds?
7. Are you a team that can use [pick & rolls/pops](#)?
8. Late Game Situations
 - o Do you foul if you’re up 3?
 - o Down 3 late in the game: Go for 3 or a quick 2 and foul (Time Permitting)?

DEFENSIVE PHILOSOPHY

Many of the details that pertain to your offense can also be upheld defensively. For example, if you love the VCU “HAVOC” style of play from Shaka Smart, you may not have the personnel on your team to maintain that pace of defense over an entire game. Also, hopefully by now you have a philosophy around running man versus zone defense or a mixture of both and you can start teaching this to your players. Here are some additional thoughts to consider:

1. [How do you guard pick and rolls](#)? (Hedge, Trap, Switch, Lift & Under, Chase, etc)
2. How do you guard pin-downs and off-ball screens? (Downscreens, Flares, Staggers, etc)
3. Where do you help and when? (Do you help from the corner on wing penetration? Are you a helping or stunting team?)
4. Are you a full-court pressing team, half-court man, or zone team?
5. Have defensive terminology for your positions (On Ball, Gap, Help); this leads to enforcing communication
6. Transition defense, stopping the ball first and closing out to help
7. How do you guard the post? (Front, 1/2, 3/4, top side, bottom side)
8. Do you want the ball forced middle or baseline/sideline?

REBOUNDING PHILOSOPHY

Some may think that rebounding should follow under offense and defense but in my opinion it is important enough to have its' own category. Some thoughts on rebounding:

1. How many players crash the boards on offense? Do you send 3, 4, or all 5 to rebound?
2. Fundamentals of blocking out. (We teach "Hit & Get"=Turn and hit your man somewhere between the knees and chest and go get the ball). Blocking out with your rear is not effective anymore.
3. Do you want to Jam the rebounder or send all 5 back on defense and retreat? (Jamming=Having closest player to the rebounder try to deflect outlet pass)

SKILL DEVELOPMENT

Before you start planning your practices, make sure you are aware of your teams' weaknesses and establish drills early to improve on these deficiencies. Whether it is shooting, ball-handling, defense, rebounding, passing, establishing a foundation of drills early will increase the level of skill improvement on your team. In addition, I love to start my practices by running several peer pressure drills to get my players warmed up and focused right from the start.

If you find it difficult to find time in your practice plan to work on skill development, don't let that be the excuse for skipping it all together. Here are some suggestions if you fit into this category:

1. Skill Development with Parts of Offense: Break down your offense into smaller parts and work on these parts. For example, if you're a pick and roll team, practice the 2-man game and have the player come off for a shot or pass to the big, have a coach/manager ready to throw a pass to the other player for a shot.
2. In the Pre-Season and on Game Days, bring your players in in the morning, or right after school, and put them through 30 minutes to an hour of skill work. Keep it lighter on game days, lots of game repetitions/shots.

I hope you have enjoyed this post and have come away with several ideas to help you in the planning process for this season. As a community of coaches, I am always looking for feedback from you for additional ideas, have I left off any important factors you consider when planning for the season?

Defensive Philosophy

https://www.coachmeyer.com/Information/Coaches_Corner/Defensive%20Philosophy.pdf

Serbia U19 defensive philosophy

<https://www.kosarkarski-trenerji.com/ftp/fiba/a28.pdf>

Youth Basketball Defensive Strategy

3/1/2020

<https://www.youthbasketballdevelopment.com/learn/youth-basketball-defensive-strategy>

We will get right to the point. For ages twelve and under no zone defense should be played as a player to player or man to man defense better develops the individual skills related to guarding a player both off and on the ball. By playing zone at such young ages the coach has made the decision to emphasize winning a tournament or game versus long-term development. Most eight through twelve years old naturally struggle with perimeter shooting from the three point line, throwing skip passes, looking defenders off and throwing the pass the other way, and being comfortable with the ball in the middle of the zone all of which makes a zone defense effective at the youth level. Fight any urge you may have to take advantage of these natural deficiencies at these young ages to win a game or keep your team in a game. In fact, FIBA (International Basketball Federation) has a “no zone defense” rule for players under the age of fourteen with the stated intent to help the development of young players both offensively and defensively.

We do recommend that you teach a player to player or man to man defense for ages fourteen and under. In our defensive team concepts section we have a progressive teaching program with appropriate drills and games specific to each age level of development. These drills and games address the core defensive concepts of proper stance, vision, anticipation, communication, and togetherness. It is important as you develop your defensive philosophy to know how you will guard the post (play behind, three-quarter deny, or full dead front), guard one pass away from the ball (be in the gap or denying), and guard ball screens (help and recover, trap, or switch) for clarity and decisiveness. Jack Bennett, the former head coach at the University of Wisconsin-Stevens Point and two time NCAA Division III National Champion said that if your team is more athletic than most teams that you will play you can get out and deny one pass away, otherwise play in the gap.

We highly recommend playing one on one each practice as able to improve on the ball defense and incorporate transition defensive work within your practice plan. If your team struggles guarding the ball or fails to make the offense go against a set defense you will struggle to defend anybody. Rebounding can be emphasized by finishing each drill with a rebound throughout your practice. Lastly, defensive breakdown drills (one on one, two on two, three on three, and four on four) are highly recommend as it forces the defense to have to cover more space.